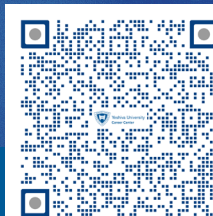


INDUSTRY OVERVIEW

GOVERNMENT AND PUBLIC SERVICE



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WHAT IS GOVERNMENT AND PUBLIC SERVICE?

Some 20 million people work for government agencies and departments (on all levels) to implement their policies and staff their programs, that, on a federal, state, or local level, handle issues as diverse as highway construction, public transportation, the protection of wilderness areas, education, public health programs, etc. Also affiliated with this type of work are volunteer or service programs based both domestically and internationally which support the philanthropic mission of the government, such as the Peace Corps. Nearly every type of position (financial analysts, lawyers, engineers, social workers, accountants, etc.) that are found in the business sector can also work in the public sector. They also include professionals who analyze policy and draft legislation for U.S. senators, people who issue building permits at town hall, and everyone in between. Research and diligence are required to find the position that fits one's interests.

While the challenge and mission of working for a government agency can be exciting, many employees state that the politics and bureaucracy can be frustrating.

SALARY EXPECTATIONS

Salary levels are based on grades within the government and the figures below roughly reflect those grades. They are not dependent on the success of the economy like many jobs in the corporate world are, thus they are relatively stable, and they have the additional benefit of regular business hours, great benefits, a reliable pension, and holiday pay (except for politically appointed positions).

There are exceptions to this, such as a political aide, who may experience instability around elections, or some programs that depend on funding, which can be cut from time to time. In general, it is less likely that one would lose one's job working for the government than lose it working for the private sector.

Salary ranges can vary from entry level, \$47,210 (political aide) to \$119,377 (Human Resource Managers).

Salaries will vary based on experience, location, and branch of government. For an overview of salary grades and salary information for specific occupations not listed below, visit the U.S. Office of Personnel Management's website at www.opm.gov.



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OUTLOOK

Employment of political scientists is projected to grow 9% from 2020 to 2030, about as fast as the average for all occupations. About half of all political scientists are employed by the federal government. Political scientists will continue to be needed in government to assess the impact of government policies, such as the efficiencies of public services, effects of budget changes, and advantages of proposed improvements. Political organizations, lobbying firms, and labor unions rely on the knowledge of political scientists to manage complicated legal and regulatory issues and policies. Political scientists will be needed at research and policy institutes to focus specifically on politics and political theory. Organizations that research or advocate for specific causes, such as immigration policy, healthcare, or the environment, also need political scientists to analyze policies relating to their field.

Candidates with advanced degrees, strong writing and analytical skills, and experience researching or performing policy analysis should have the best job prospects. Candidates who have specialized knowledge or experience in their field of interest will also have better job opportunities. Internships or volunteer work also may be helpful.

U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, U.S. Department of Labor, Occupational Outlook Handbook, Political Scientists, bit.ly/36y5A3M

CAREER TRACKS

The most common government agencies and departments in the U.S. include: Congressional Budget Office, Army Corps of Engineers, Metropolitan Transit Authority/Port Authority, Federal Bureau of Investigation, Department of Homeland Security, Internal Revenue Service, National Museums (i.e., Smithsonian), Local Law Enforcement, Department of State Parks, Department of the Treasury, Department of Defense, Department of Transportation, International Trade Commission, Department of Veteran's Affairs, Federal Trade Commission, Environmental Protection Agency, Office of Government Ethics, National Archives and Records Administration, Public Libraries, Congress/Elected Representatives (federal, state, and local), Department of Education, Immigrations and Customs Enforcement Bureau, Department of Justice.

Common career tracks include:

- Criminal Investigators and Special Agents
- Environmental Specialists
- Foreign Service Officers
- Intelligence Officers
- IRS Budget Analysts
- Legislative Staff Assistants/Associates

- Policy Consultants
- Political Aides
- Public Affairs Specialists

Entry level titles within this industry include:

- Constituent Assistant
- Human Resources Assistant
- Political Aide

SKILLS AND ABILITIES

Most positions require a B.A. in a related field, depending on the specific area of government. More advanced positions might require an MPA or some continued training in specific skills. Some entry-level positions require employees to take the Civil Service Exam, a government sponsored test.

CAREER RESOURCES

- [Careers in Government](#)
- [Federal Employees Career Development Center](#)
- [GovtJobs](#)
- [Idealist](#)
- [NYC.gov](#)
- [Peace Corps](#)
- [USA Jobs](#)
- [U.S. Department of State—Careers Representing America](#)
- [U.S. Office of Personnel Management](#)
- [U.S. Pirg](#)

PROFESSIONAL NETWORKING ORGANIZATIONS

- [American Public Works Association](#)
- [The Council of State Governments](#)
- [Government Finance Officers Association](#)
- [International Institute for Democracy and Electoral Assistance](#)
- [National Association of Counties](#)
- [National Conference of State Legislatures](#)
- [Public Citizen](#)
- [Sustainable Communities](#)